distance(A,B) + distance(B,C) = distance(A,C), the points A, B and C must be collinear.

Similarly, when A, B and C are the vertices of a right angled triangle, $\angle ABC = 90^\circ$ we know that:

distance$(AB)^2$+ distance$(BC)^2$ = distance$(AC)^2$

with appropriate naming of vertices. We can also show that the converse holds: whenever the equality here holds for A, B and C, they must be the vertices of a right angled triangle.

The following examples illustrate how these properties of distances are useful for answering questions about specific geometric shapes.

Example 5.4

Find the distance between the points (–4, 3), (2,–3).

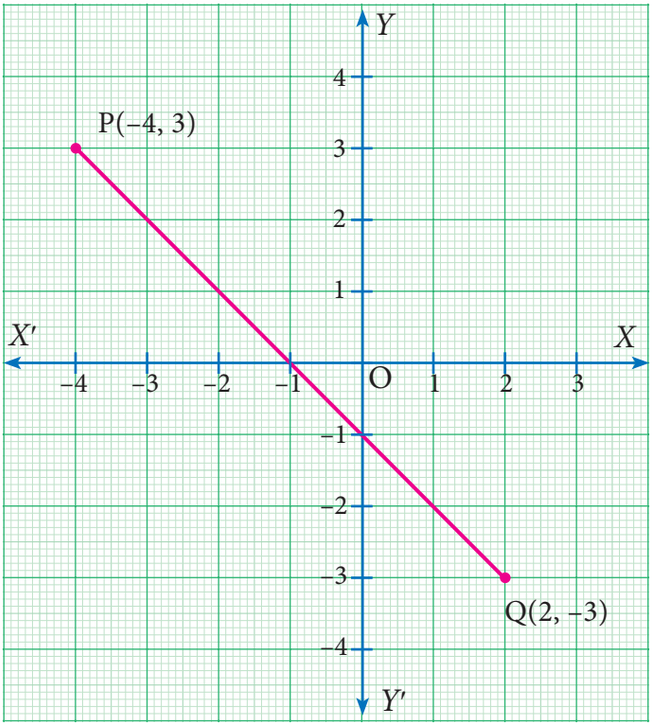


Fig. 5.19

Solution

The distance between the points (-4, 3), (2,-3) is

$$d = \sqrt{(x_2 - x_1)^2 + (y_2 - y_1)^2}$$

$$= \sqrt{(2+4)^2 + (-3-3)^2}$$

$$= \sqrt{(6^2 + (-6)^2)} = \sqrt{(36+36)}$$

$$= \sqrt{(36 \times 2)}$$

$$= 6\sqrt{2}$$

Example 5.5

Show that the following points $A(3,1)$, $B(6,4)$ and $C(8,6)$ lies on a straight line.

Solution

Using the distance formula, we have

$$AB = \sqrt{(6-3)^2 + (4-1)^2} = \sqrt{9+9} = \sqrt{18} = 3\sqrt{2}$$

$$BC = \sqrt{(8-6)^2 + (6-4)^2} = \sqrt{(4+4)} = \sqrt{8} = 2\sqrt{2}$$

$$AC = \sqrt{(8-3)^2 + (6-1)^2} = \sqrt{25+25} = \sqrt{50} = 5\sqrt{2}$$

$$AB + BC = 3\sqrt{2} + 2\sqrt{2} = 5\sqrt{2} = AC$$

Therefore the points lie on a straight line.

Collinear points

To show the collinearity of three points, we prove that the sum of the distance between two pairs of points is equal to the third pair of points.

In otherwords, points A, B, C are collinear if $AB + BC = AC$

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